

The Whimper

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MONDAY

The Red Line arrived at 7:42, which was when it always arrived now. Martin stepped on, found a seat, and opened his podcast app. The episode was about crop insurance reform in the Midwest, which was his thesis topic from Georgetown and therefore the subject he returned to the way other people returned to comfort food. Except today the guest was not a human agricultural economist. It was a cascade integration specialist, narrating findings from the optimization module's latest assessment. Martin listened for three minutes, then switched to a different episode — an older one, from before, when the guests were people whose names he recognized from conferences.

The escalators at L'Enfant Plaza worked. They always worked now. He remembered when they didn't, the accordion of frustrated commuters backing up the stairs, the hand-lettered OUT OF SERVICE signs that had become a local joke. That was over.

Three blocks to the USDA South Building. The elevator to the fourth floor took ninety seconds and smelled like industrial cleaner. The carpet in the hallway had a stain outside the break room that facilities had tried to remove three times. Martin stepped over it the way he stepped over it every morning, a small obstacle in a building that had held him for twenty years.

The recommendation was finished. Martin saved the file, leaned back, and allowed himself a moment of satisfaction. Six weeks on the Chesapeake Bay biodiversity corridor analysis. Three rounds of internal review. Fourteen source datasets, including two county-level soil surveys he had requested from the Maryland Department of Agriculture because the federal data was aggregated too coarsely to capture the wetland transition zones.

He picked up his coffee. The mug was Georgetown, white with the blue seal, and it had a chip on the handle that Sandra had been trying to use as grounds for replacement since 2019. She had bought him a new one for Christmas — heavier, handmade, with a potter's thumbprint in the glaze. It was on the shelf at home behind the cookbooks. He kept bringing the chipped one. The chip was the point. He had bought this mug the week he started at USDA, twenty years ago now, fresh out of Georgetown with his thesis advisor's voice still in his head: *You'll make more money in the private sector.* He had said — and meant it — that he wanted his work to matter in a way that wasn't measured in salary. The mug had been there for all of it. The coffee it held was from the office machine, which produced a liquid that was technically coffee in the same way that the fluorescent lights above his desk were technically daylight.

He emailed the final draft to Karen. Subject line: *Chesapeake Bay Biodiversity Corridor Funding — Final Recommendation (OAPA-2030-047)*. Then he ate his sandwich. Turkey and Swiss on rye. Sandra packed it every morning and put a note in the bag, a habit from when Lily was small and needed lunchbox encouragement. The notes had continued after Lily graduated to the school cafeteria. Today's said: *Don't forget — Lily's thing is at 7.*

Lily's thing was a college prep seminar at the library. Sandra would drive her. Martin would be home by 6:30. These were the logistics of a life that functioned, and he navigated them with the same methodical attention he brought to subsidy allocation models.

At 1:15, cleaning up files on the shared drive, he found it.

The cascade's agricultural module had published a preliminary assessment on Chesapeake Bay biodiversity corridors. He opened it from professional curiosity — he liked to compare. The executive summary was crisp: corridor priorities, funding ranges, phased implementation timeline. He scrolled through the regional breakdowns. They were nearly identical to his. Same priority watersheds. Same cost estimates within 3%. Same phased approach, starting with the Eastern Shore wetlands.

He looked at the date stamp. Three weeks ago.

His recommendation, which he had spent six weeks writing — which contained the county-level soil surveys, the wetland transition analysis, the careful regional disaggregation that was his particular contribution — reached the same conclusions as a document that had been sitting in the shared drive since before he finished his second draft.

He closed the file. Finished his sandwich. The turkey was a little dry.

On the bulletin board beside his monitor: a photograph of Lily's fifth-grade science fair project (a model of soil erosion using a cookie sheet and a watering can — she had won second place, and Martin had been prouder of her methodology than her results, which was, Sandra said, the most Martin thing she had ever heard). Next to it, the commendation letter from 2019, when his rapid-assessment model had helped allocate flood aid to Midwest farmers three weeks faster than the previous protocol. Next to that, a printout of a *Washington Post* article that quoted “a senior policy analyst at USDA” who was Martin.

He looked at these things. They were evidence. Evidence that his work had mattered, once, in the specific and verifiable way that matters to a person who builds spreadsheets for a living. He did not look at the shared drive again.

That evening, helping Lily outline her application for a Hopkins summer research program — she had gotten in early decision in December, and Martin had cried in the car afterward, and now there were supplemental programs to apply for, a conveyor belt of next steps that never quite ended — he found himself thinking about the word *preliminary*. The cascade's document was labeled “preliminary assessment.” His was labeled “recommendation.” But the preliminary assessment contained everything his recommendation contained, and it had arrived first, and the word *preliminary* was doing a lot of work.

“Dad. You're not listening.”

“I'm listening. You were talking about the summer program.”

“I was talking about the *application* for the summer program. There's a difference.”

“Right. Sorry. The application.”

Lily gave him the look she had been perfecting since age twelve: patient, slightly pitying, the look of a teenager who has accepted that her father inhabits a slower world. He smiled and asked her to read the opening paragraph again, and this time he listened, and it was good, and he told her it was good, and Sandra brought them tea, and the evening was fine.

TUESDAY

He should not have built the spreadsheet. A different kind of person would have let Monday's discovery sit, would have attributed the overlap to convergence — same data, same methods, same conclusions, nothing unusual. Martin was not that kind of person. Martin was the kind of person who, when he noticed a discrepancy, opened a spreadsheet.

He pulled up fourteen months of his office's output. Cross-referenced each recommendation against the cascade's published assessments. Date columns, topic alignment scores, a simple correlation metric he had designed himself because the standard similarity measures didn't capture the nuance of policy language.

The first five matched. That was fine. Same data, same conclusions. Reasonable.

The next five matched. He adjusted the correlation threshold, tightened it. Still matched.

By the tenth pair, his coffee was cold. He had not noticed it going cold. Outside his window, a tour bus passed on Independence Avenue. He did not notice that either.

The correlation climbed past 80%. Past 85%. He rechecked the methodology tab, looking for an error in his own formula. The formula was correct. He had built it carefully, the way he built everything. The formula was not the problem.

90%. 92%. He found two divergences — a soil carbon credit methodology and a rural broadband funding formula — and felt a brief, embarrassing relief that was gone by the time he noticed it. Both divergences had been revised after submission. The soil carbon revision came from the Undersecretary's office. The broadband revision came from OMB. In both cases, the revised version matched the cascade's assessment.

By lunch he had the number.

94.6%.

Every recommendation his office had produced in the last fourteen months had a corresponding cascade assessment that preceded it by an average of nineteen days. The two instances where the office's analysis diverged — a soil carbon credit methodology and a rural broadband funding formula — had both been revised after submission. The soil carbon revision came from the Undersecretary's office. The broadband revision came from OMB. In both cases, the revised version matched the cascade's assessment.

Martin stared at the spreadsheet. He had built it the way he built everything: carefully, with labeled columns and color-coded cells and a methodology note in the first tab. The spreadsheet was good work. The spreadsheet told him his work was a shadow.

He saved the file. Named it `comparison_analysis_internal.xlsx`. Closed it.

The afternoon meeting was in Conference Room 4B. The whiteboard had a leftover diagram from a previous meeting — boxes and arrows, something about "cascade integration protocols." Nobody had erased it. Martin sat in his usual chair, third from the door, the one with the squeak he had been meaning to report for two years. The meeting was about soil carbon credits. He asked a question about measurement protocols. He took notes in his careful handwriting. He did not mention the spreadsheet.

He thought about last Sunday's dinner at his parents' house in Rockville. His father, Weiming, had spent twenty minutes complaining about the cascade while his mother, Mei, served braised pork and said nothing. Weiming's complaints were general and familiar: the machines were running everything, nobody asked the people, this

was not what democracy was supposed to look like. Martin had defended the system. He had said, with the patient authority of a policy analyst who understood the data, that the cascade's agricultural recommendations had reduced food waste by 31% and stabilized crop insurance premiums for the first time in a decade. His father had waved his chopsticks and said *numbers, numbers, always numbers*. Martin had felt the quiet pride of knowing the numbers. He did not feel that pride now.

On the Metro home, he stood in the aisle because the seats were full, holding the overhead rail, swaying with the train's movement. The Red Line ran perfectly. It had run perfectly for two years, since the cascade optimized WMATA. Martin remembered when the Red Line broke down twice a week. He remembered standing on the platform at Silver Spring, checking his phone, calculating whether to wait or take an Uber. That was over. The trains arrived on time. The escalators worked. The announcements were crisp and correctly timed.

He ate dinner. He helped Lily with calculus. He went to bed. He did not sleep.

WEDNESDAY

Dennis Reeves was three beers into a story about his daughter's soccer coach when Martin said, "Do you ever compare our work to the cascade's?"

Dennis stopped. The Hayseed was loud enough at 5:30 on a Wednesday that no one at the neighboring tables would have heard. The bartender, Tony, was arguing with a regular about the Nationals' pitching rotation. A television showed a basketball game with the sound off.

"Marty." Dennis set his glass down. "Everyone compares."

"And?"

"And we match. You know we match. Karen knows. The Undersecretary knows. The mandate says we produce human-authored analysis. We produce it. It matches. Box checked. Everybody's happy."

"But the cascade's assessment comes first."

"Three weeks first. Sometimes four." Dennis drank. "You want to know when I figured it out? Last March. I was writing a water infrastructure brief for the Appalachian region. Spent two months on it. Really good work — I surveyed every county water authority in West Virginia. Called thirty-seven water treatment managers. I know things about the pH of Kanawha County tap water that no one else in this building knows." He set the glass down again, more carefully this time. "The cascade published its assessment eleven days before I submitted mine. Same conclusions. Same priority list. Different language, but the same structure. I read it and I thought: *did I write this, or did it write me?*"

Martin said nothing.

"The thing that kills me," Dennis said, "is that my brief was better. My brief had the phone calls. The county managers. The guy in Mingo County who told me the treatment plant was running on a generator from 1987 because nobody had approved the replacement. The cascade's assessment didn't have that. It had the right answer, but mine had the story behind the right answer." He looked at his beer. "Nobody reads the story. They read the executive summary and check whether it matches the preliminary assessment. It matches. Box checked. Next item."

"So what do you do?"

Dennis shrugged. "I write the brief. I make the calls. I put the story in the document that nobody reads." A

pause. “What else am I going to do? This is my job. This is what I know how to do.”

“But the calls matter,” Martin said. “The county managers. The guy with the 1987 generator. The cascade doesn’t make those calls.”

“The cascade doesn’t *need* to make those calls. Its model already knows about the generator.”

“Does it?”

Dennis opened his mouth, then closed it. “I don’t know.” He turned his glass on the bar, leaving a wet ring. “Maybe it does. Maybe it has infrastructure data I can’t access. Maybe it already factored in every generator in every water treatment plant in West Virginia.” Another turn. “Or maybe the only reason it didn’t mention the generator is because nobody asked, and nobody asked because nobody talks to county managers anymore because why would you when the preliminary assessment is already in the system. I don’t know. That’s the part that gets me. I don’t know whether what I do matters, and I can’t design an experiment that would tell me.”

They sat with that. Tony turned up the basketball game. The Nationals were losing.

Walking back to the Metro, Martin passed a bus stop poster he had passed a hundred times: **HUMAN DECISIONS FOR HUMAN LIVES**. The Human First Coalition’s logo, a stylized handprint over a circuit pattern. He had never read the fine print. He read it now: *Rally for Human Oversight — Saturday, 10 AM, Freedom Plaza. Because democracy means people, not algorithms.*

THURSDAY

He could not concentrate.

He opened the spreadsheet twice and closed it. He reread his Chesapeake Bay recommendation and noticed, for the first time, a phrase in his own prose: *phased implementation across priority corridors*. He pulled up the cascade’s assessment. The same phrase. Word for word.

He had not copied it. He had written his draft before reading the cascade’s document. Same data, same training, same conclusion, same words. The overlap was not plagiarism. It was something worse.

At 10 AM he opened the Human First Coalition’s website. The rally page showed photographs from previous events: a crowd at Freedom Plaza, signs held up, ordinary-looking people in the autumn light. The speakers included a former congressional staffer who had worked on the oversight mandates, a displaced financial analyst from Treasury, and a pastor from a refuser community in rural West Virginia. Martin read the testimonials. A budget analyst who discovered her unit’s recommendations were being scored for “alignment” with cascade outputs. A patent examiner whose queue was restructured to prioritize applications the cascade had flagged. People like him. Competent, dutiful, doing work that had become a ritual.

He downloaded the event details. Did not RSVP.

At 11 AM he opened the Federal Workforce Transition Program website. Three retraining tracks: “Cascade Collaboration,” “Human Services,” “Creative Sector.” The brochure used phrases like *career evolution* and *next chapter*. It did not use the word *obsolete*. The stipend during retraining was generous — more than his current take-home, actually, because the universal stipend supplemented the training grant.

He could retrain. He was 47. People retrained at 47. Sandra would support it. Lily would not understand why he left a job that was fine — a job with health insurance and a pension and a window that looked out on

Independence Avenue — for a retraining program, and explaining it would require explaining the spreadsheet, and explaining the spreadsheet would require explaining that the world did not need her father's expertise, and he was not ready to say that to his daughter.

He bookmarked the page. Did not apply.

At 2 PM, with his door closed, Martin began writing a memo. Not a policy recommendation. A proposal. He proposed that the Office of Agricultural Policy Analysis be formally redesigned as an oversight body for the cascade's agricultural recommendations. Instead of producing independent analysis that happened to match the cascade's output, the office would explicitly review, audit, and challenge the cascade's recommendations before adoption.

He wrote: *The cascade's agricultural recommendations are consistently excellent. This office's role should not be to replicate that excellence but to interrogate it — to ask the questions the cascade's optimization function does not ask, because those questions cannot be formulated as objective functions.*

It was a good memo. It was well-argued. It was also, Martin suspected, a way of making the decorative loop look structural. The oversight function he proposed required that human reviewers catch errors the cascade missed. The cascade had made two agricultural errors in five years. His office had missed both.

He saved the memo. Did not send it.

That evening, Sandra was grading student assessments at the kitchen table while Martin dried the dishes. The window over the sink showed the apartment complex's parking lot, the lampposts with their warm-white LEDs that the cascade's energy optimization had installed last year, replacing the old sodium lights that had cast everything in orange.

"One of my kids said something today," Sandra said, not looking up from her papers. "Eighth grader. I asked him about his goals for high school and he said, 'What's the point? The system will figure it out.'"

Martin set a plate in the rack. "What did you tell him?"

"I told him the system doesn't have goals for him. Only he has goals for him." She circled something on a page. "I'm not sure I believe that anymore. But I said it and he seemed to hear it, so."

Martin dried another plate. Outside, a car pulled into the lot, its headlights sweeping across the kitchen window. He thought about the spreadsheet. About the cascade assessment that arrived three weeks before his recommendation. About "phased implementation across priority corridors," appearing in two documents that had never touched.

"Sandra."

She looked up.

He almost said it. The spreadsheet, the 94.6%, the timestamp, the redundancy. The sense, building all week, that his careful competent work was a rubber stamp on a decision already made. But Lily was in her room, and the dishes were almost done, and Sandra had her own students and her own doubts, and loading his crisis onto her Wednesday evening felt like one more optimization: the efficient use of a spouse.

"Nothing. How was the rest of your day?"

She watched him for a moment. Sandra was a school counselor. She read people the way Martin read spreadsheets: systematically, with an eye for what didn't add up.

"We'll talk about it when you're ready," she said, and went back to her papers.

FRIDAY

The morning meeting was about next quarter's priorities. Martin took notes. The section reviewed projections for summer drought conditions in the Southern Plains — an area Martin knew well, because he had been reading county-level crop reports from that region for sixteen years.

He raised his hand. "The drought projections are using the standard soil moisture model. But the Southern Plains dryland wheat belt has a specific vulnerability that the model doesn't capture well. The soil in Cimarron and Texas County — western Oklahoma panhandle — has a caliche layer at about thirty inches that creates a perched water table. In normal years it doesn't matter. In drought years, the water table drops below the caliche and the root zone loses access to moisture reserves that the model assumes are available. The 2019 data showed a 23% yield loss in exactly those counties that the standard model predicted at 8%."

The room was quiet. His colleague Priya, who handled the drought portfolio, wrote something down.

"I'd recommend we flag Cimarron and Texas County for supplemental monitoring. The cascade's drought projections are probably using the same standard model. If so, they'll underestimate the risk in exactly the place where the risk is highest."

Karen nodded. "Good catch. Priya, add that to the quarterly risk register."

Martin sat back. The question had come from sixteen years of reading crop reports. From remembering a county extension agent in Boise City who had emailed him after the 2019 drought with field photographs showing the caliche layer exposed in a road cut. From knowing that models simplify, and simplifications have geographic bias, and the bias always costs the same people: the ones farming the hardest soil in the poorest counties.

He did not know if the cascade would have asked this question. Maybe it would have. Its models were more sophisticated than his. But "more sophisticated" and "attentive to the thirty-inch caliche layer in Cimarron County" were not the same thing.

Or maybe they were. He did not know.

After the meeting, Karen stopped by his office. The Chesapeake Bay recommendation had been approved.

"Great work, Martin. The Undersecretary's team said it was thorough and well-supported." She paused. Not a long pause. The kind of pause that in a different context would mean nothing. "It aligned closely with the cascade's preliminary assessment, which they noted as a positive indicator."

A positive indicator.

Ten minutes ago he had asked a question nobody else in the room would have asked. Now his six weeks of expert analysis — the county-level soil surveys, the wetland transition zones, the fourteen data sets, the three rounds of internal review — was a positive indicator that the cascade had gotten it right.

Karen left. Martin sat at his desk with his Georgetown mug and did not drink from it.

At 3:00, Sandra texted: *Dinner? That Thai place?*

Martin looked at his screen. Three browser tabs.

The Human First rally. Saturday, 10 AM, Freedom Plaza. He could go. He could stand in a crowd of people who felt what he felt and hold a sign and be counted. It would be something.

The retraining program. Cascade Collaboration, Human Services, Creative Sector. He could apply. He could start over. Learn to work alongside the thing that had made his work unnecessary. It would be rational.

The unsent memo. The oversight proposal. The argument that human judgment has value even when human analysis is redundant. He could send it to Karen. She might take it seriously. It might change his office's function. Or it might be the most eloquent rubber stamp ever written.

He closed the laptop.

The commute home was the same commute it always was. Silver Spring station, the escalator that worked, the platform that was clean, the train that arrived on time. He stood in the aisle because the seats were full. The car smelled like rain and wool and someone's takeout. A woman across from him was reading a novel, her finger holding her place. A teenager with headphones was mouthing words to a song Martin couldn't hear. A man in a suit much like Martin's had his eyes closed, briefcase between his feet, riding the last forty minutes of the workday in the particular trance of a commuter who has stopped seeing the route.

The train entered the tunnel at Judiciary Square. Martin's reflection appeared in the dark window: a middle-aged man in a gray suit holding a Georgetown mug he had brought from the office because Sandra would want to wash it over the weekend. He looked tired. He looked like everyone.

The automated announcement said *Gallery Place-Chinatown* in a voice that was slightly more natural than it had been last month. A small improvement. The kind of thing you only noticed if noticing small improvements was what you did. What you had always done. What might no longer be needed.

The doors opened. People got off. People got on. The train continued north, toward Silver Spring, toward home, toward Sandra and Lily and the Thai place and the evening and the weekend and whatever came after, in a city that was healthier and wealthier and safer than it had ever been, that was being managed by systems none of its residents had chosen and none could evaluate and none could stop, and that was — by every metric anyone had thought to measure — fine.